2012 | Sells his majority stake in Pantaloon Retail to Aditya Birla Nuvo, the latter to invest Rs 1,600 crore in Pantaloon Retail

2015 | Launches white-label FMCG products under Future Consumer Enterprises, allowing people to shop from, and take deliveries, anywhere

Dec. 2019 | Amazon acquires 49 per cent in Future Coupons, a promoter group entity of Future Retail, for around Rs 2,000 crore

Oct. 2020 | A single bench of the Singapore International Arbitration Centre (SIAC) bars Future Retail from taking any step to sell its assets to another party. The battle moves to the Indian courts



Aug. 2020 | Future Retail sells its retail, wholesale, logistics and warehousing units to Reliance Retail for Rs 24,713 crore

Feb. 2022 | Reliance Retail takes over 400 Big Bazaar stores where Future Group defaulted on lease renewals

Apr. 2022 | Supreme Court disposes of the case, allows arbitration proceedings before SIAC between Amazon and Future Retail

Jul. 2022 | NCLT admits Bank of India's insolvency plea for Future Retail, appoints interim resolution professional

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The Future Group's five listed companies and their market capitalisation as on Aug. 31, 2022

BIG BAZAAR	FUTURE GENERALI	FLF	FUTURE CONSUMER	FSC
FUTURE RETAIL Big Bazaar and other neighbourhood chains	**FUTURE ENTERPRISES** Retail infrastructure and insurance	**FUTURE LIFESTYLE FASHIONS** Fashion brands and retail chains	**FUTURE CONSUMER** Food and FMCG	**FUTURE SUPPLY SOLUTIONS** Supply chain networks
199.6	81.4	262.3	337.5	120

(Figures in Rs crore)

However, in the case of Future Retail, it had already reached the brink of a new inning with Reliance Retail as the owner before the deal was scuttled by the legal proceedings initiated by Amazon. This has also made it more painful for Biyani to see a quick revival of his business, although under a new management. Sadly, at the end of the saga, there will be no clear winners. It has thwarted Ambani's plans to own a large chunk of the organised retail market and keeping a check on arch-rival Amazon. But it has also dashed Amazon's hopes of getting a share of the brick-and-mortar Future Retail's assets in future. The biggest losers, however, will be the lenders, suppliers and staff of Future Retail. The Future Group owes its 26 lenders, including Bank of India which moved the NCLT for Future Retail's insolvency, over Rs 15,000 crore.

According to Devangshu Dutta, the CEO of Third Eyesight, a consulting firm, Reliance Retail's takeover of the Big Bazaar stores is the "tipping point" in the entire Future Retail saga. Without some of the flagship Big Bazaar stores, the value of Future Retail would be considerably weakened. Dutta argues that Reliance Retail is a gainer in the whole deal, since it has managed to wrest control of a good number of stores. Moreover, according to him, the deal with Future Retail not going through is indeed an opportunity lost for the company but is certainly not anything too drastic. Reliance Retail would also be a potential bidder for Future Retail once it is put up for auction. "Future Retail would have been a good addition to RIL's portfolio. But they don't need Future to grow. However, Amazon has lost significantly. The momentum they (Amazon) could have got from Future Retail has been taken off the table now," Dutta says. "Moreover, under the country's FDI laws, Amazon cannot bid as an operating company (for Future Retail in the auctions)." He also calls for better regulation of the sector by strengthening the CCI by adding more retail sector experts to the body.

The Indian retail sector is once again turning into a hotbed of competition on the back of an aspiring middle class, a high proliferation of smartphones and internet services. It has now been established that both the physical as well as the online models of retail will go hand in hand, complementing each other, as has been witnessed in developed retail markets worldwide. Although the future of Biyani's Future Retail is now at stake, the retail story in itself is far from over. Many feel that a feisty and sharp entrepreneur like Biyani could still spring a surprise and come up with something new. He named his 2011 autobiography *It Happened in India*. There could be much more that could happen in the Indian retail space and to entrepreneurs like Biyani in future. ■